

song. A 10-band equaliser, in-line ID3 tag editing, and many more features make it a must-have player. Though meant for KDE, AmaroK is also available for other Linux distros running GNOME as well. Visit <http://amarok.kde.org/amarokwiki/index.php/Download> for download instructions for your distribution.

6.1.2 VLC Media Player

VLC (earlier VideoLAN Client) is a highly portable multimedia player for various multimedia formats including MPEG-4, DivX, MP3, ogg, etc. It can also play DVDs, VCDs, and various streaming protocols. The name VideoLAN comes from the fact that it can also be used as a server to stream video in multicast (stream to many systems) IPv4 or IPv6 on a high-bandwidth network.

VLC Media Player can be downloaded from www.videolan.org/vlc/. There are separate downloadable packages for different distributions.

6.2 Codecs

The word “codec” comes from “Coder-Decoder.” This is a file or a set of files that are used to encode an audio or video data into a particular format for storage. Often, the encoding is performed to compress the data in order to save disk space. Once the audio or video data is stored in a format, it has to be decoded so that it can be played. Basically, the compression has to be interpreted in the correct way for the video or audio to be extracted. There are many different video formats and not all of them are open source. So those proprietary codecs may not be available on open source OSes.

The most popular codec today is the DivX codec, which produces excellent quality video output with smaller file sizes as compared to other formats. For a PC with a lot of videos, DivX Player is a must-have. At the time of writing, the Linux page on the DivX Web site was down. Do check <http://www.divx.com/divx/linux/> sometime for download instructions. This apart, you may need